

The Adviser's Trade, Recut

A market, buyer, and positioning primer for SRJ International's general-practice homepage

Industry Briefing No. 2 | SRJ International | August 2026

Prepared for the SRJ International engagement.

Abstract

SRJ is not moving from a marketing-agency niche into an undifferentiated market called "small businesses." It is moving to a general owner-managed-business practice with specific reasons to choose it.

A homepage that says "accounts, tax, VAT and payroll for businesses" enters a commodity comparison. A homepage that says "tax decisions planned before the money moves" enters a judgment comparison. Simon's credible assets - Chartered Tax Adviser, Chartered Accountant, former PwC experience, direct access, a complete compliance practice, and work across owner-managed businesses - support the second position.

The market opportunity is the recurring gap between what owners think an accountant will do and what a basic compliance engagement supplies. Owners expect warnings, options, forecasts, and advice in time to act. Many receive accurate filings after the useful decisions have passed. Software makes the filing layer cheaper and more visible; it does not remove the need for judgment where the company and the owner's personal tax collide.

The proposed market position is:

A Chartered Tax Adviser-led accountancy practice for UK business owners who need decisions planned before the money moves.

The practice remains general. Its public doors are specific:

1. profit extraction and owner tax;
2. UK and international complexity, initially UK/UAE;
3. exit and succession readiness;
4. proactive financial control rather than retrospective filing;
5. sector proof for agencies, professional services, landlords, dentists, contractors, and other suitable owner-managed businesses.

This is **general practice, specific spikes**. The homepage sells the common problem. Search and service pages sell the specific situations.

How to use this book

Three evidence types are kept separate throughout:

- **Verified fact:** a figure, rule, or statement supported by an official or primary source current at the date of this primer.
- **Field signal:** language or behavior observed in public buyer discussions, especially Reddit. It is qualitative evidence, not a representative survey.
- **Strategic inference:** a conclusion drawn from market evidence, competitor review, SRJ's material, and Simon's repositioning. It must still be tested against sales calls and client economics.

Tax rules are simplified to explain the market. They are not client advice. Eligibility, connected companies, residence, treaties, anti-avoidance provisions, and individual facts can change the result.

Contents

PART ONE - THE TRADE AND THE MARKET

- 1 The trade: compliance records the past; advice shapes the future
- 2 The market is large; the useful market is narrow
- 3 What is changing in accountancy

PART TWO - THE OWNER AND THE MONEY

- 4 Why owners hire, stay, and switch
- 5 The 2026/27 decision calendar
- 6 The owner-managed business is one economic system
- 7 The decision-support opportunity

PART THREE - THE SPECIFIC SPIKES AND THE VOICES

- 8 Specific spike one: UK and international complexity
- 9 Specific spike two: exit and succession readiness
- 10 Field research: how buyers describe the problem

PART FOUR - HOW THE BUYER CHOOSES

- 11 How buyers judge an accountancy firm
- 12 Price, value, and offer design
- 13 Competitor map
- 14 SRJ's current assets and gaps

PART FIVE - THE POSITION AND THE HOMEPAGE

- 15 Positioning and message architecture
- 16 Homepage structure dictated by the buyer journey
- 17 Copy directions and claims discipline

PART SIX - DECISIONS, LIMITS AND SOURCES

- 18 What Simon must decide before final copy
- 19 Research limits and next evidence
- 20 Final position
- A Sources

Chapter 1 - The trade: compliance records the past; advice shapes the future

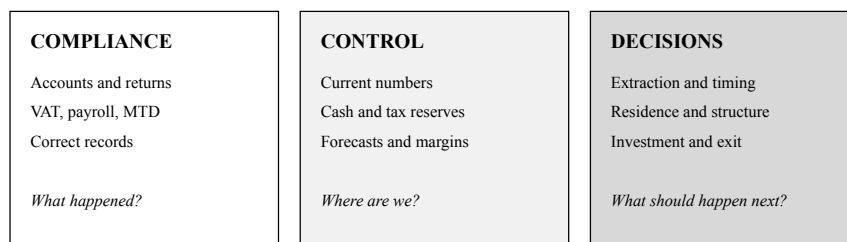


Figure 1. The same practice sells three different outcomes. Compliance is the base; the commercial distinction sits above it.

"Accountant" sounds like one service. For an owner-managed business it contains at least three layers.

Layer 1: statutory compliance

Annual accounts, corporation tax, VAT returns, payroll, confirmation statements, self assessment, bookkeeping, and Making Tax Digital keep the business legal and its records usable. This work is essential. It is also increasingly standardised, portal-led, and software-assisted.

The client buys successful completion: correct filings, known deadlines, reconciled records, and fewer surprises from HMRC or Companies House.

Layer 2: financial control

Management accounts, cash-flow visibility, tax reserves, debtor awareness, margin analysis, forecasts, and a regular review rhythm tell the owner what is happening before the year is over.

The client buys orientation: what is real profit, what cash is committed, where performance is changing, and what requires attention now.

Layer 3: owner and business decisions

Structure, extraction, pensions, investment, hiring, VAT consequences, residence, cross-border income, succession, and exit planning affect what the owner keeps and what the business becomes.

The client buys judgment: options explained, consequences modelled, and decisions made while there is still time to change the outcome.

The filing layer answers, "What happened?" The control layer answers, "Where are we?" The advisory layer answers, "What should we do next?"

This is not an argument for belittling compliance. Poor compliance destroys trust and can create penalties, buyer concerns, and expensive correction work. It is an argument for making compliance's role clear: the accurate foundation of an advisory relationship, not the whole promise.

Homepage consequence: do not begin with the service catalogue. Begin with the timing and quality of decisions the owner is making without enough information.

Chapter 2 - The market is large; the useful market is narrow

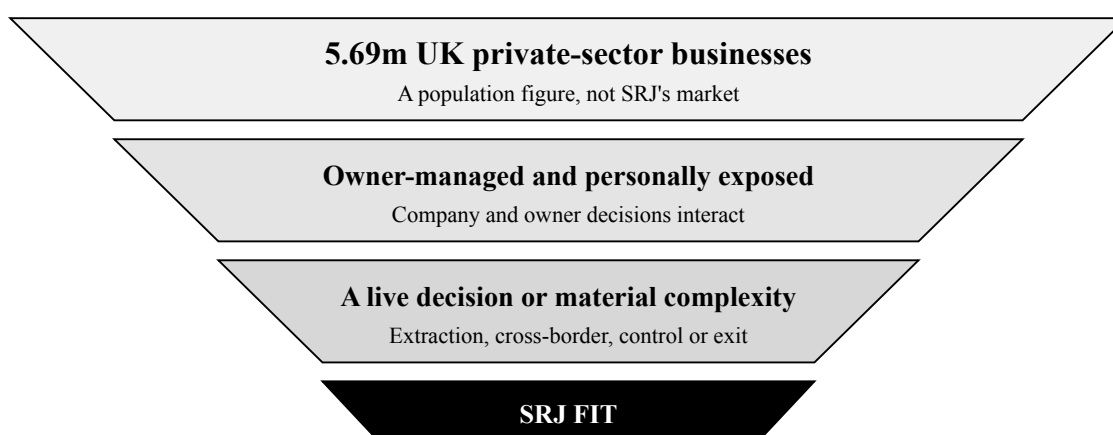


Figure 2. Headline market size is not the addressable market. Need, complexity and willingness to engage do the qualifying.

The UK had an estimated **5.69 million private-sector businesses** at the start of 2025.

Approximately **5.64 million** were small businesses with 0-49 employees, and **4.3 million** had no employees. About **2.1 million** were actively trading companies, while approximately **3.2 million** were sole proprietorships.¹

HMRC separately describes approximately **5.3 million customers as small businesses**, generally with turnover under GBP 10 million and fewer than 20 employees. HMRC's estimated small-business tax gap for 2024/25 was GBP 36.7 billion.²

Those numbers explain why government policy focuses on small-business compliance. They do not define SRJ's addressable market. A sole trader with a simple return, no planning question, and a price-first mindset is technically in the market but is unlikely to value Simon's strongest capabilities.

The useful SRJ market

The useful market is an owner whose business and personal finances have begun to interact in ways that create decisions:

- a limited-company director taking salary, dividends, pension contributions, or loans;
- a profitable sole trader deciding whether incorporation is worthwhile;
- an owner approaching VAT, personal allowance, child-benefit, or pension thresholds;
- a founder who lacks timely management information despite paying for accounts;
- a UK owner moving abroad, returning to the UK, or earning across borders;
- a landlord entering Making Tax Digital or changing residence;
- an owner preparing for succession or sale;
- a business with enough complexity that errors, delay, and fragmented advisers create material risk.

Turnover is only a rough proxy. A GBP 100,000 consultancy with foreign income and a director near multiple thresholds can need more judgment than a GBP 500,000 domestic business with clean records and simple transactions. Transaction volume, payroll, VAT treatment, group structure, residence, property, investments, owner goals, and record quality all affect complexity.

A practical segmentation

Buyer state	Trigger	Private fear	Decision wanted	Best SRJ door
Growing owner-manager	Profit and cash have increased	"I cannot tell what is mine"	Extraction, reserves, forecast	Tax planning and control
Under-advised existing client	Accountant files but rarely initiates	"I am finding out too late"	A proactive review rhythm	Adviser-led accountancy
Internationally mobile owner	Moving, returning, or earning abroad	"Two advisers tell me different things"	Coordinated UK position before action	UK/international tax
Exit-minded founder	Sale possible within 1-5 years	"It may be worth less without me"	Clean numbers and buyer-risk reduction	Exit readiness
Compliance-frustrated business	Missed messages, staff churn, deadline anxiety	"Nobody owns my account"	Reliable completion and named contact	Direct Simon access
Software-capable price buyer	Comfortable doing the books	"Am I paying for data entry?"	Review and advice where valuable	Clear responsibilities

Strategic inference: qualify by decision complexity and desired relationship. Industry and turnover are insufficient on their own.

Chapter 3 - What is changing in accountancy

Routine work is becoming easier to compare

Cloud ledgers, bank feeds, receipt capture, payroll platforms, Companies House integrations, and automated reminders make routine work more transparent. Some owners can do a credible part of the bookkeeping themselves. Online providers package standard limited-company compliance at a visibly low monthly price.

This creates price pressure where work is described as tasks. If two firms both promise annual accounts, corporation tax, payroll, and VAT, the buyer can compare monthly fee and review count. The more the service looks like data processing, the less a premium credential explains the price.

Automation does not make advice automatic. It makes current data easier to obtain. Someone still has to decide whether the data is reliable, interpret it in context, spot a threshold or risk, and recommend what to do before the owner commits.

Buyers increasingly expect advice

ICAEW's 2026 discussion of the advice businesses want highlights management information, budgeting and forecasting, cost control, strategic planning, restructuring, and wealth or succession planning.⁴ The common thread is decision support, not production of annual accounts.

A much older ICAEW small-business study found high use of external accountants but a much lower incidence of business-advice work. It also reported that owners viewed a good accountant relationship as valuable.⁵ Its percentages are dated and should not become current claims, but the structural gap remains visible in current buyer discussions: an accountant can be trusted and still be used too narrowly.

Administrative burden increases the need for translation

The Administrative Burdens Advisory Board's 2025 survey received 3,146 responses from businesses and agents. A majority expected no benefit from Making Tax Digital and anticipated more time or cost; 57% said the burden of tax legislation had worsened. Respondents criticised communications that were difficult to understand.³

The homepage should not complain about HMRC. The implication is that plain-English translation is part of the product. The adviser turns rules, letters, thresholds, and deadlines into an ordered next step.

The profession is consolidating

ICAEW describes consolidation, technology investment, and changing client expectations as part of a structural change in accountancy.⁶ Larger groups can invest in systems, specialist teams, marketing, and acquisition. They can also produce adviser turnover, centralised queues, and a less personal service.

An independent practice cannot out-resource a consolidator. It can compete on continuity, senior attention, speed of judgment, and a coherent view of owner and company. Those benefits must be operationally true. "Personal service" is weak copy unless prospects can see who answers, how reviews happen, and what remains directly with Simon.

Credentials have unusual commercial value

HMRC states that it does not regulate tax agents and that anyone can call themselves a tax agent.⁷ ICAEW explains that "accountant" is not, by itself, an indication of qualification; ACA or FCA status carries training, ethical, continuing-development, disciplinary, and insurance expectations.⁸ CIOT positions CTA as a rigorous tax credential governed by professional and ethical requirements.⁹

This makes Simon's CTA and ACA credentials commercially important, particularly for complex decisions. Initials alone are insider language. The site should translate them:

- **Chartered Tax Adviser:** specialist tax training and professional standards;
- **Chartered Accountant:** broad accountancy, financial, and professional grounding;
- **former PwC:** experience formed in a large professional-services environment;
- **direct adviser access:** continuity and accountability in a smaller practice.

All directory links and exact credential wording must be verified before publication.

Chapter 4 - Why owners hire, stay, and switch

Most people do not wake up wanting a new accountant. Switching carries uncertainty, documents, awkwardness, and fear that something will be lost between firms. A generic promise of "proactive advice" rarely overcomes inertia.

Common hiring triggers

1. **A threshold appears.** Turnover approaches VAT registration; income approaches GBP 100,000; profit supports larger dividends or pensions.
2. **A life event changes the problem.** The owner moves country, buys or sells property, adds a shareholder, receives foreign income, or considers a sale.
3. **The current accountant goes quiet.** Messages are slow, the adviser changes, or contact only happens at filing time.
4. **A surprise bill breaks confidence.** It may be correct, but the owner did not understand it early enough to reserve cash or change course.
5. **The owner outgrows annual information.** They need cash forecasts, margins, or a decision model.
6. **Software exposes the service gap.** The owner does most categorisation and uploading, then questions the monthly fee.
7. **An external party raises the standard.** A bank, investor, buyer, lawyer, or overseas adviser requests better information.

What clients mean by proactive

"Proactive" is overused because it is rarely defined. Buyers usually mean observable behaviors:

- contact occurs before a deadline or decision;
- the adviser raises issues the client did not know to ask about;
- options and consequences are explained alongside the rules;
- the owner knows when the next review will happen;
- advice connects business numbers to personal goals.

It does not mean the accountant continuously invents tax savings. Some clients buy only statutory work. Some advice requires separate scope and fee. The commercial failure occurs when the engagement is ambiguous: the owner assumes advice is included, the accountant assumes compliance was bought, and both discover the mismatch after a problem.

The emotional jobs

- **Control:** "I know what is due and what I can safely do."
- **Timeliness:** "I will hear while there is still an option."
- **Translation:** "I understand the consequence without reading legislation."
- **Ownership:** "A qualified person knows my situation and owns the next step."

"Peace of mind" is common but too vague as a headline. Show what creates it: known reserves, planned reviews, direct answers, clear responsibilities, and no handoff when judgment is needed.

Why clients do not switch

- fear that professional clearance will be difficult;
- uncertainty about records and software access;
- worry that the outgoing accountant will delay;
- concern about setup or catch-up fees;
- doubt that the new service will actually differ;
- preference for a known frustration over an unknown failure.

Offer consequence: "We handle the switch" should be concrete. Explain professional clearance, software access, record transfer, opening balances, missing-work review, and any setup fee before the prospect asks.

Chapter 5 - The 2026/27 decision calendar

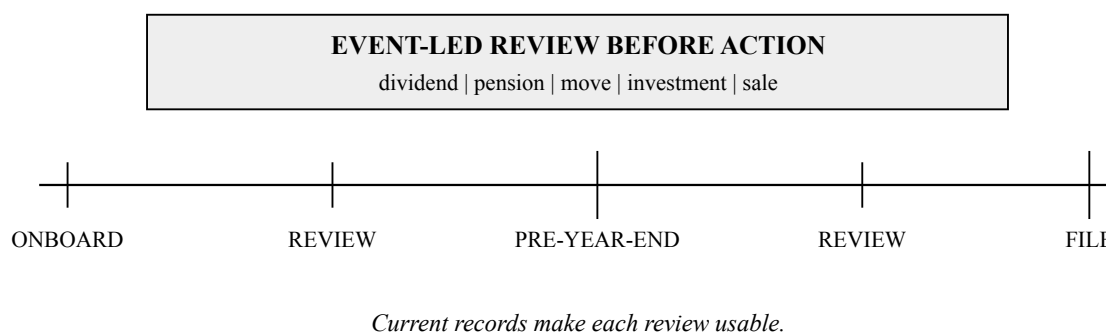


Figure 3. A service calendar is the concrete version of 'proactive'. Event-led reviews sit on top of the agreed recurring rhythm.

Current rules make "before the money moves" more than a slogan. Several decisions are materially different from assumptions an owner learned a few years ago.

Corporation tax

The small-profits rate is **19%** for profits up to GBP 50,000 and the main rate **25%** above GBP 250,000, with marginal relief between. Thresholds are reduced for associated companies.¹⁰

For the owner, this creates questions about profit timing, pension contributions, capital expenditure, group structure, and whether cash retained after corporation tax is available for extraction.

VAT

The registration threshold is **GBP 90,000** and the deregistration threshold **GBP 88,000**.¹¹

VAT can change pricing and margin, particularly for businesses selling to consumers or partially exempt customers. Artificially suppressing growth is not a strategy. Forecasting the rolling threshold, setting prices correctly, and choosing the right scheme are the useful decisions.

Salary, dividends, and employer National Insurance

For 2026/27, the personal allowance remains **GBP 12,570** and begins to taper when adjusted net income exceeds GBP 100,000.¹² The dividend allowance is **GBP 500**, with dividend rates of **10.75%, 35.75%, and 39.35%** according to band.¹² Employer National Insurance is **15%**, with a **GBP 5,000** secondary threshold for most employees.¹³

"Small salary plus dividends" is a starting pattern, not sufficient advice. The answer depends on other income, allowance, Employment Allowance eligibility, company profit, spouse circumstances, pensions, benefits, and cash need.

Pensions

The standard annual allowance remains **GBP 60,000**, but tapering and carry-forward can change it.¹⁴ Employer contributions may be an extraction and corporation-tax planning tool where commercially justifiable. The money is inaccessible until pension conditions are met; it is not a universal substitute for income.

Business Asset Disposal Relief

The Business Asset Disposal Relief rate is **18%** for qualifying disposals from 6 April 2026.¹⁵ Qualification and lifetime limits matter, and sale structure can change the result. Planning after heads of terms may be too late to alter ownership history or correct weaknesses.

Business Relief for inheritance tax

From 6 April 2026, 100% Business Relief is subject to a **GBP 2.5 million allowance**, with 50% relief generally applying above it, subject to detailed rules.¹⁶ Succession and estate-planning coordination becomes more relevant for valuable trading businesses. The accountant should work with legal and financial advisers where the problem crosses boundaries.

Making Tax Digital for Income Tax

MTD for Income Tax applies from April 2026 to qualifying sole traders and landlords with gross qualifying income over **GBP 50,000**, then **GBP 30,000** from April 2027 and **GBP 20,000** from April 2028.¹⁷

This is a switching and onboarding window. The buyer problem is maintaining compatible digital records, submitting updates, understanding workflow, and using more frequent data for something useful.

Companies House identity verification

Mandatory identity verification began rolling out for new directors and people with significant control from 18 November 2025, with existing directors and PSCs in the transition.¹⁸ This adds administrative value to company-secretarial support but is not a major advisory proposition.

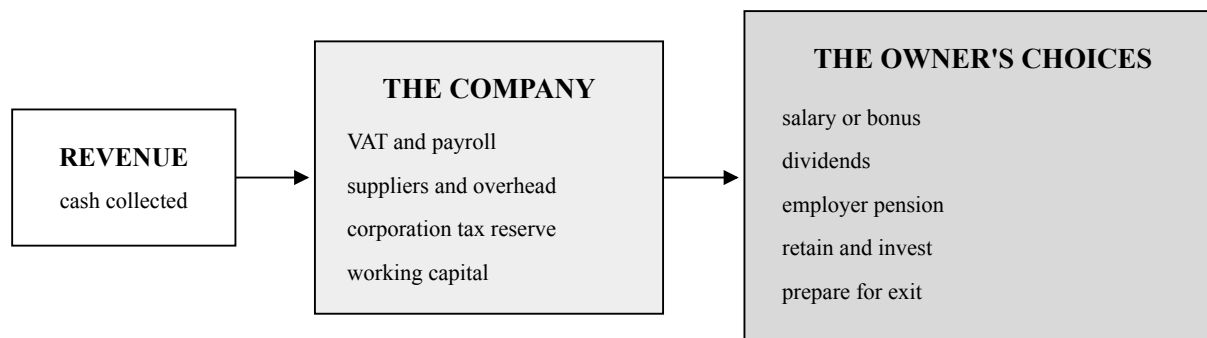
Why a calendar matters

Tax planning is often sold as a year-end meeting. The owner needs a series of moments:

- onboarding and baseline cleanup;
- quarterly or agreed performance and reserve reviews;
- a pre-year-end options review while transactions can change;
- a personal tax review before extraction hardens;
- event-led reviews before incorporation, relocation, investment, succession, or sale.

Product consequence: define when advice happens. A cadence is more credible than the adjective "proactive."

Chapter 6 - The owner-managed business is one economic system



Bank cash is not the same as money available to extract.

Figure 4. The owner experiences one money system even though the company and shareholder are legally separate.

Legally, company and shareholder are distinct. Economically, the owner experiences one system.

Money enters the company. VAT may be embedded in it. Wages, suppliers, subscriptions, debt, and corporation tax consume part. The owner decides whether remaining value should be salary, dividend, pension, reinvestment, retained cash, or preparation for sale.

The owner is simultaneously asking:

- Can the company afford this?
- Can I personally afford this?
- What tax follows each route?
- What does this do to next quarter?
- Does this make the business stronger or merely move cash?

A large bank balance can create false confidence. Cash is not distributable profit. Distributable profit is not automatically the best dividend. A lawful dividend is not automatically a sensible extraction decision.

The extraction model

1. **Salary or bonus:** generally deductible when properly incurred, but exposed to PAYE and NIC.
2. **Dividends:** paid from distributable post-tax profits, without NIC, but taxed personally and subject to company-law formalities.
3. **Employer pension contribution:** potentially efficient, but constrained by tax, commercial, and access considerations.
4. **Benefits or expenses:** useful only where legitimate and correctly treated; not a bag of loopholes.
5. **Loan account movement:** needs control because overdrawn balances can create company and personal tax consequences.
6. **Retention:** leaves capacity for working capital, investment, resilience, or an eventual transaction.

The adviser's value is not choosing the route with the lowest isolated tax percentage. It is modelling owner cash need, reserves, time horizon, other income, allowances, and risks together.

Thresholds connect the choices

The personal allowance taper above GBP 100,000, pension tapering, dividend bands, child-benefit charge, student-loan exposure, and household circumstances can make one additional dividend affect several outcomes. Planning is valuable because thresholds interact, not because one rate is secret.

The management-information bridge

Extraction advice is only as good as the numbers underneath it. A practice cannot credibly advise a dividend, pension contribution, or investment if bookkeeping is months behind and profit uncertain.

This gives compliance a stronger frame:

| Clean records are what make a timely decision defensible.

The advisory offer connects bookkeeping quality, management information, tax reserves, and owner decisions. It does not bolt an annual tax-planning call onto stale records.

Chapter 7 - The decision-support opportunity

Many owners do not need a fractional CFO. They need dependable answers to four questions:

1. What did the business actually earn?
2. Where did the cash go?
3. What is committed to tax and other obligations?
4. What can we safely do next?

Useful management information

The exact pack should match the business. Common components include:

- profit and loss against prior period or budget;
- balance sheet with unusual balances explained;
- cash position and short forecast;
- aged receivables and payables;
- tax reserve and upcoming liabilities;
- gross margin by relevant service, product, or client type;
- owner drawings, dividends, and loan-account position;
- a short action list with responsibility and date.

A 20-page report without interpretation is not necessarily advisory. A one-page decision summary using reliable numbers can be.

Annual accounts are too late for operational decisions. Quarterly reviews suit some stable businesses and are too slow for others. Monthly reporting may matter where payroll, projects, inventory, debtors, or cash volatility are material. Promise an agreed rhythm based on decisions, not one cadence for everyone.

The practice should distinguish statutory compliance, management reporting, tax planning, project advice, and specialist transaction/legal/investment advice. Scope discipline protects margin and trust.

Chapter 8 - Specific spike one: UK and international complexity



Conflicting advice must be resolved before implementation.

Figure 5. The useful UK/UAE offer is coordinated analysis. SRJ owns the UK answer; local advisers confirm the foreign answer.

SRJ's local search evidence is small but directionally important. In the 20-day Search Console sample ending 4 August 2026, agency terms sat roughly in positions 59-83. A few international-tax queries appeared much closer to page one, and UK-Dubai/UAE terms generated a larger cluster around positions 39-44.²⁸

The sample cannot prove demand or authority. It shows the domain has a more plausible early association with international questions than its agency-only homepage suggested. "SRJ International" also supports this territory naturally.

The real UK/UAE buyer problem

The weak promise is "move to Dubai and pay no tax." It attracts avoidance-led intent, creates regulatory risk, and ignores residence, company management, UK-source income, temporary non-residence, and the other country's position.

The stronger promise is:

Know what still follows you from the UK before you move, restructure, invoice, or extract money.

Common questions:

- When do I cease to be UK resident?
- Can split-year treatment apply?
- Can I run my UK company from abroad?
- Where is the company centrally managed and controlled?
- Should a UAE entity invoice the UK company or customers?
- How are salary, dividends, duties, and UK workdays treated?

- What happens to UK property income?
- What if I return within five years?
- Which adviser owns the joined-up answer?

UK residence is determined through the Statutory Residence Test, including day counts, work, home, and connection factors. Split-year treatment applies only in specified cases.¹⁹

From 6 April 2025, qualifying new UK residents after at least ten tax years of non-UK residence may claim the four-year Foreign Income and Gains regime, subject to detailed conditions.²⁰

Temporary non-residence rules can bring certain income and gains into charge when a person returns. Returning within five years may be relevant depending on prior residence and the item.²¹

From April 2026, post-departure close-company distribution rules broaden the potential UK charge on return.²²

Service boundary

Simon can credibly lead UK analysis if his experience supports it. The site must not imply SRJ supplies UAE legal, regulatory, immigration, or tax advice unless genuinely in scope and appropriately authorised. A strong offer can be coordinated:

- SRJ owns the UK tax and company analysis;
- assumptions and unresolved foreign questions are written down;
- an appropriate UAE adviser confirms local treatment;
- conflicts are reconciled before implementation.

Coordination itself has value. Buyer discussions show people receiving incompatible answers from a UK accountant and a UAE formation or tax adviser.

Useful content doors include moving from the UK while owning a UK company, central management and control, salary/dividends after departure, UK property, temporary non-residence, and a pre-departure decision checklist. Each page needs a date, named technical reviewer, primary sources, and a route to advice.

Chapter 9 - Specific spike two: exit and succession readiness

An exit is where the owner discovers whether years of accounts created a filing history or a transferable business record.

What buyers examine

- sustainable earnings rather than one strong year;
- recurring or repeatable revenue;
- customer and supplier concentration;
- dependence on the founder;
- management-information quality;
- working-capital requirements;
- defensible add-backs;
- employment and contractor treatment;
- VAT, corporation-tax, payroll, and loan-account exposure;
- ownership, options, shareholder agreements, and relief eligibility;
- whether forecasts reconcile to operating reality.

The owner's question is often "What multiple will I get?" The earlier question is "What is the business worth without me, and what would make a buyer discount it?"

The accountant's legitimate role

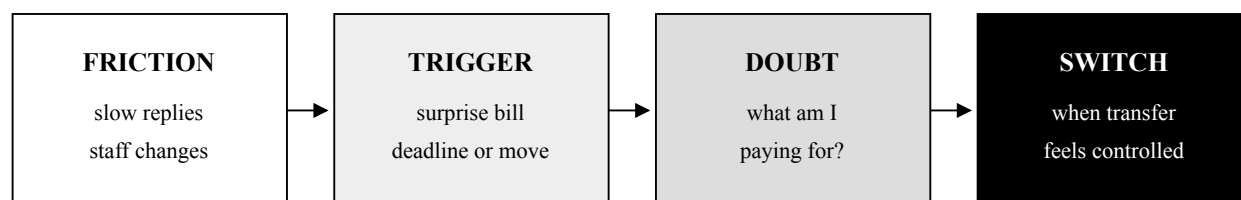
SRJ can potentially help clean records and balance-sheet anomalies, produce credible management accounts, document owner or exceptional costs, identify tax issues before diligence, model after-tax proceeds, check ownership facts relevant to reliefs, and coordinate lawyers, corporate-finance advisers, and wealth planners.

Tax readiness is not sector valuation, buyer sourcing, negotiation, legal structuring, or running a transaction. Use "exit readiness" or "tax planning before a sale" unless Simon can evidence a broader M&A service.

The door is commercially useful because it attracts established owners with material stakes. It gives ordinary accountancy work a future purpose: clean records, current information, owner independence, and tax planning help build a stronger business now.

A first offer could be an **Exit Readiness Review** covering accounts quality, tax housekeeping, founder and customer concentration, ownership facts to confirm, adviser requirements, and a 12-24 month action sequence. Valuation, legal, and investment questions outside scope should be explicit.

Chapter 10 - Field research: how buyers describe the problem



The new accountant must make professional clearance and catch-up work legible.

Figure 6. The public threads describe a sequence, not a vague desire for better service.

Public Reddit threads were reviewed in the current Reddit interface using a browser session. Post dates, visible scores, comment counts, and text were captured during August 2026. These threads are not statistically representative and participants may be wrong. Their value is language, objections, and recurring situations.

"Correct" is not the same as useful

In "How proactive are your accountants?", an owner of a low-seven-figure-turnover business said the annual accounts were correct but prepared only after year-end, with "never any sort of feedback or planning or proactive advice." The owner was willing to pay more but had not been offered a different service.

Replies exposed the market boundary. Some accountants said statutory accounts were what the owner bought and consulting costs extra. Others recommended monthly management accounts, projections, and scenario work because quarterly or annual information can arrive too late.

Interpretation: the product and timing were not explicit. SRJ should say what is included, what is reviewed, and when.

Software makes weak service easier to leave

In "I want to sack my accountant and do it myself", a limited-company owner described errors, rising prices, slower service, unanswered email, and phone access replaced by ticketing. Replies ranged from DIY through FreeAgent to a hybrid where the owner maintains records and an accountant reviews, files, and advises.

Interpretation: bookkeeping is not a durable premium by itself. SRJ must show review, anticipation, judgment, and time returned.

Peace of mind is operational

In a fee-and-service reassurance thread, a sole trader around GBP 130,000 turnover was switching because of poor communication and no clear process. The accountant reportedly contacted them shortly before a VAT deadline, creating panic. The buyer wanted statements, receipts, deadlines, and decisions organised in advance.

Interpretation: reassurance comes from a service calendar, clear requests, visible responsibilities, and early warnings.

The switch is a sales objection

In "Switching accountants - is it pretty painless?", an owner feared obstruction by the outgoing accountant. Replies described normal professional clearance while warning about timing, exit fees, missing work, and access to software and records.

Interpretation: explain that SRJ contacts the previous accountant, reviews completed work, secures records and access, and confirms catch-up work before proceeding.

Owners compare the scope behind the price

In "Accountant quote - am I being rinsed?", a one-director company around GBP 100,000 turnover compared a GBP 340 monthly quote plus setup with lower examples. Replies varied according to bookkeeping, payroll, VAT, personal returns, calls, and tax planning. Several distinguished low-cost online compliance from an accessible adviser.

A separate GBP 250-per-month discussion made the economic point: using a highly qualified person for every standardised task increases cost; premium one-contact advice can still make sense. Another UK cost thread showed why turnover alone is weak: transaction volume, Stripe, VAT, payroll, offshore bookkeeping, and record quality changed the workload.

Interpretation: package and qualify by workload, complexity, responsiveness, and advice.

Exit value is reduced by owner dependence and uncertainty

In a sub-GBP 10 million exit discussion, an owner above GBP 7 million revenue wanted a realistic view 12-18 months before sale. Replies raised founder dependence, recurring revenue, clean books, tax issues, and what the business was worth without the owner. They also separated the accountant who cleans numbers from the transaction adviser who knows buyers and sector multiples.

Interpretation: SRJ can own accounting and tax readiness, then coordinate valuation and sale specialists.

International owners reconcile two systems

In "Non-resident director of UK company tax liability", a person moving to Dubai wanted to remain "above board and legal" but received conflicting guidance. Questions covered UK company management, a UAE entity, transfer pricing, salary/dividends, and customer perception.

Interpretation: the buyer is not simply asking for formation. They want one coherent decision sequence and a clear owner for UK analysis.

Scaled providers create a continuity opening

Public complaints about large online services include ticketing, repeated requests, changing contacts, and deadline anxiety. These are individual reports, not a reliable assessment of any firm's overall service.

Interpretation: do not attack scaled competitors. Show the structural difference: named adviser, agreed response route, planned reviews, and a clear line between processing staff and Simon's judgment.

The buyer-language bank

- "I find out after year-end."
- "I want to know in the same tax year."
- "I do most of it in the portal."
- "I do not know what I am paying for."
- "I want peace of mind."
- "Tell me what you need and when."
- "Will the old accountant hold things up?"
- "What is the business worth without me?"
- "I am getting conflicting advice."
- "I want it above board and legal."

These are stronger copy inputs than "bespoke solutions," "trusted partner," or "comprehensive support."

Chapter 11 - How buyers judge an accountancy firm

Stage 1: category recognition

The prospect asks, "Is this firm for someone like me?" A broad homepage still needs recognisable situations: a profitable owner-managed company, a landlord entering MTD, an international move, a possible sale, or dissatisfaction with retrospective accounts.

Stage 2: competence

They look for qualifications, named people, professional directories, relevant technical content, experience, and evidence that the firm understands the exact problem.

Stage 3: relationship risk

They ask who will answer, whether the senior person disappears after the sale, how queries are handled, and whether they will repeat their circumstances to several people.

Stage 4: process

They want to know what happens first, how switching works, what records are needed, when reviews occur, and where responsibilities sit.

Stage 5: proof

They compare third-party reviews, specific testimonials, client examples, and consistency of published expertise. Claims on the firm's site are weaker when no external corroboration exists.

Stage 6: price and scope

They ask whether the fee covers bookkeeping, payroll, VAT, personal tax, software, meetings, ad hoc questions, tax planning, and catch-up work. A high fee becomes alarming when its scope is unclear.

Stage 7: safety

For tax, the prospect needs confidence that advice is legitimate, documented, and appropriately cautious. Aggressive promises can reduce trust among better clients.

Homepage consequence: credentials without process feel remote; process without credentials feels lightweight; both without proof remain self-assertion.

Chapter 12 - Price, value, and offer design

The market contains four economic models.

Low-cost software-led compliance

The client accepts standard workflows, self-service, and pooled teams for transparent pricing and convenience. This is difficult to beat on price and should not be SRJ's target comparison.

Traditional annual compliance

The firm completes accounts and returns, often with a named contact, but advice is mainly reactive or event-led. Many owner expectations become stuck here.

Adviser-led recurring service

Compliance is combined with current records, periodic review, tax planning, and senior access. The buyer pays for cadence and judgment, not merely more deliverables.

Project advice

Relocation, residence, restructuring, cleanup, investigations, succession, and sale planning require a scoped fact pattern, written analysis, and coordination. They should not disappear inside an "unlimited advice" package.

A useful SRJ architecture

1. **Compliance foundation:** annual accounts, corporation tax, filings, and agreed bookkeeping/payroll/VAT responsibilities.
2. **Owner planning:** scheduled performance, tax-reserve, extraction, and pre-year-end reviews.
3. **Decision projects:** cross-border, incorporation, restructuring, exit readiness, and complex one-off analysis.

The site does not have to display fixed prices. It should explain what changes the fee:

- entity and group structure;
- number and type of returns;
- transaction volume and record quality;
- payroll and VAT complexity;
- reporting frequency;
- owners and personal returns;
- international facts;
- direct advisory work;
- catch-up or correction required.

The value equation

Tax saved is one form of value. Others include penalties and correction costs avoided, cash reserved before liabilities, owner time returned, an earlier decision, a bad structure not implemented, cleaner information for a lender or buyer, reduced transaction risk, and confidence to extract money lawfully and sustainably.

Tax-saving claims should be specific, evidenced, and accompanied by the conditions that produced the result. A universal "we save more than our fee" promise is not defensible.

Chapter 13 - Competitor map

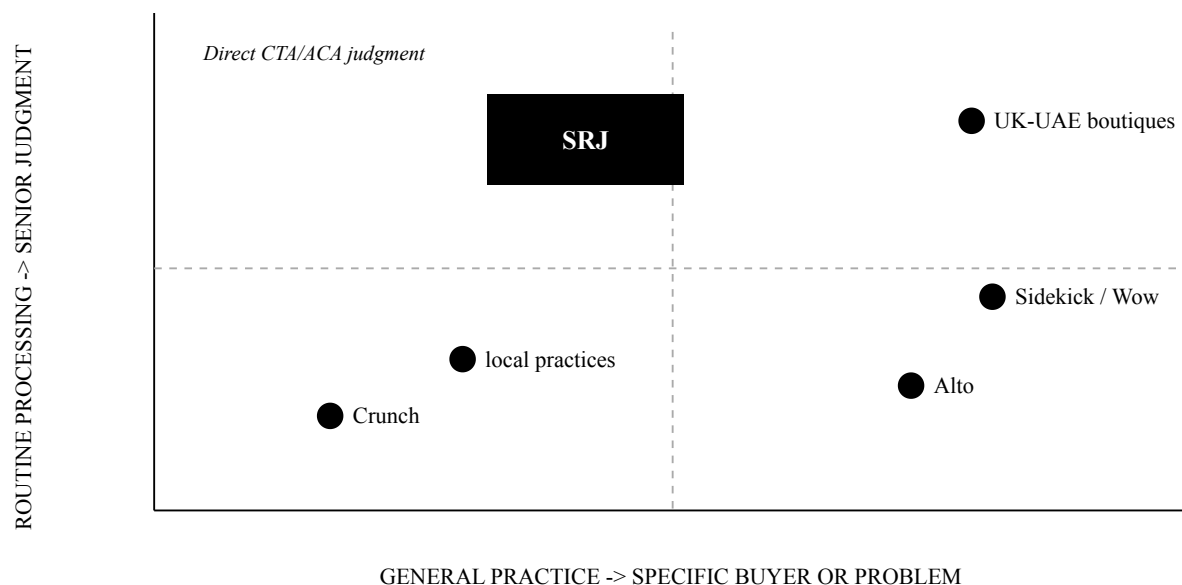


Figure 7. SRJ should sit above routine compliance without pretending to be a foreign-law or transaction firm.

The competitor is not one local firm. It is a set of propositions the buyer can choose instead.

Competitor	What it wins on	Buyer appeal	Pressure on SRJ	SRJ separation	Claim to avoid
Crunch	Transparent packages, software, scale, visible proof	Convenience and known cost	Standard compliance is easy to compare	Named CTA/ACA judgment and continuity	Scaled firms cannot advise
Alto	Agency specialism, direct language, fixed fees, switching reassurance	"They understand my agency"	High bar for sector relevance	Broader owner tax and international/exit spikes	Broad is always better than specialist
Sidekick	Large agency content footprint, benchmarks, service ladder	Education and growth support	Strong organic category ownership	CTA-led owner tax and direct access	Generic content volume will compete
The Wow Company	Community, benchmarks, strategic identity	Peer context and reputation	Proprietary-data and community moat	Individual tax/business coordination	Community claims without assets
Protax	London general practice, prices, reviews, named professional	Familiar local-accountant purchase	Stronger external proof and price anchoring	Timing/mechanism position and CTA translation	Credentials alone are unique
Q Accountants / UK-UAE firms	Corridor identity and relocation relevance	One place for UK/UAE questions	Immediate international relevance	Conservative UK-led analysis and coordination	Unverified UAE capability

Cross-border boutiques	Owner-managed international complexity	Specialist confidence	Compete for high-value cases	Simon's experience plus full-practice continuity	Generic "international" claims
Local chartered practices	Breadth, locality, referrals, long relationships	Trust and convenience	Established reviews and networks	Specific spikes and planned cadence	Ordinary full service is unique

What the live competitors teach

Crunch publishes limited-company packages from GBP 94 plus VAT per month, a large review claim, and a dedicated-team proposition.²³ It anchors the low end of a credible national service. SRJ should not put the same deliverable list beside it without explaining the relationship and advice difference.

Alto speaks precisely to agencies: retainers, media pass-through, freelancer churn, lumpy cash, monthly reporting, fixed fees, and a 30-day switch.²⁴ This is strong vertical copy. SRJ should retain an agency page with this recognition while removing agency exclusivity from the homepage.

Sidekick combines agency content, benchmarks, and a service ladder from foundations to CFO support.²⁵ Its moat is accumulated category evidence, not one headline.

The Wow Company uses community, benchmarking, and strategic support for agencies, consultancies, and technology businesses.²⁶ This is a system of proof, not a phrase to copy.

Protax gives buyers visible entry prices, a named FCCA, and third-party-review reassurance.²⁷ It shows how a smaller general practice can reduce purchase uncertainty.

Strategic inference: SRJ should not choose between "general" and "specialist." It needs a general homepage, technically specific service pages, sector proof pages, and a recognisable Simon-led service model.

Chapter 14 - SRJ's current assets and gaps



Figure 8. The previous homepage led with marketing agencies. The design can stay; the category signal and copy sequence must change.

Assets already present

1. **CTA and ACA credentials.** A stronger combination than the unqualified word "accountant," especially for owner tax and cross-border questions.
2. **Former PwC experience.** Useful shorthand for technical and professional grounding when stated accurately.
3. **A full compliance practice.** Advice can be implemented through the same relationship.
4. **Direct Simon identity.** A named practitioner can compete against queues, tickets, and account-manager turnover.
5. **Cross-sector client proof.** Existing testimonials refer to a digital marketing agency, dentist, and landlord.
6. **Existing agency content.** It becomes a sector acquisition asset rather than discarded work.
7. **Early international search association.** Too small to call traction, but enough for disciplined testing.
8. **A viable mechanism.** "Tax planned before the money moves" works across extraction, international moves, and exits.

Material gaps

1. **External review proof.** No dependable public review count has been verified for the homepage.
2. **Credential links.** CIOT and ICAEW records and permitted logo usage need confirmation.
3. **Testimonial attribution.** The dentist testimonial may conflict with original-message attribution in the source material. Resolve it before publication.
4. **Quantified outcomes.** "Saved thousands" requires permission, correct attribution, and context.

5. **Defined ideal client.** Turnover, minimum fee, record quality, geography, and exclusions need Simon's decision.
6. **Visible advice cadence.** "Proactive" needs operational detail.
7. **Cross-border scope.** Countries, case types, partner network, and written-advice capability need confirmation.
8. **Exit evidence.** Relevant work, transaction experience, and partners need confirmation.
9. **Case studies.** Three specific cases would do more than a long service list.
10. **Off-site authority.** The SEO research correctly identifies corroboration, author identity, links, and third-party presence as constraints.²⁹

The proof sequence to build

1. Verify professional directory profiles and credentials.
2. Resolve every testimonial's person, business, wording, and permission.
3. Establish a compliant public-review request process.
4. Write three cases around situation, decision, work, and result.
5. Add named technical authorship and source dates to tax content.
6. Build referral relationships for UAE, legal, corporate-finance, and wealth questions outside scope.
7. Record sales-call language and update this primer after 10-20 suitable enquiries.

Chapter 15 - Positioning and message architecture

The category

SRJ is an **adviser-led accountancy practice for owner-managed businesses**.

"General accountancy" is operationally true but commercially empty. "Tax advisory" alone may make routine clients assume SRJ does not handle accounts, VAT, payroll, and bookkeeping. The joined category preserves both.

The positioning statement

SRJ International is a Chartered Tax Adviser-led accountancy practice for UK business owners who need tax and financial decisions planned before the money moves.

The primary problem

The owner has an accountant or software that records what happened, but lacks a clear view before taking income, crossing a threshold, moving country, investing, or preparing to sell.

The mechanism

Accurate records create a current view. Scheduled reviews expose decisions. Simon models the tax and cash consequence before implementation. Compliance records and files what was decided.

Diagnose -> Plan -> Maintain

- **Diagnose:** understand company, owner, records, obligations, and next decisions.
- **Plan:** compare options, timing, tax, cash, and professional boundaries.
- **Maintain:** keep records and filings accurate, review at the agreed cadence, and revisit when facts change.

The promise

Know what is yours, what is committed, and what each decision is likely to change before you act.

Reasons to believe

- Chartered Tax Adviser and Chartered Accountant;
- former PwC experience;
- one practice spanning compliance and tax advice;
- direct access to the named adviser;
- evidence across more than one owner-managed sector;
- specific international and exit-readiness capability where verified.

Who it is for

- UK owner-managed businesses that value advice as well as filing;
- directors whose extraction and personal tax need coordination;
- owners with international facts or a planned move;

- businesses preparing for succession or sale;
- clients willing to maintain usable records and engage before deadlines.

Who it is not for

- buyers choosing solely on the lowest monthly fee;
- people seeking untested schemes or a promised zero-tax answer;
- clients unwilling to provide records until filing time;
- foreign legal, immigration, investment, or regulated advice outside scope.

The exclusions need not all appear on the homepage. They should shape qualification and tone.

Chapter 16 - Homepage structure dictated by the buyer journey

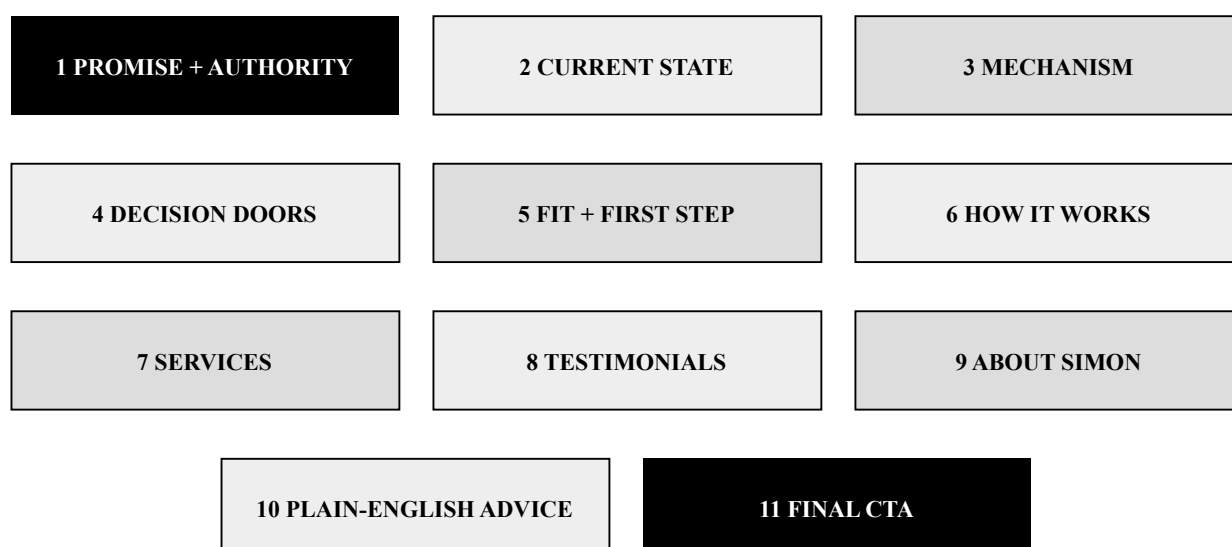


Figure 9. The homepage follows the buyer's risk in order. Detailed tax content comes after the principal conversion path.

The Copy Bible's broad logic is **Headline -> Lead -> Body -> Close**, with disruption, intrigue, authority, proof, and a clear value trade. For SRJ, it becomes this sequence.

1. Hero: disrupt and promise

Purpose: distinguish retrospective accounting from timely advice.

Copy tags: Header, Subheader, Primary CTA, Secondary CTA.

Identify the owner-managed business and timing mechanism. Do not list every service above the fold.

2. Authority strip: remove qualification risk

Purpose: answer "Why trust this person with tax decisions?"

Copy tags: Credentials, Proof Points.

Use CTA, ACA, former PwC, and direct Simon involvement. Explain the credentials nearby or in supporting content.

3. Current state: show recognition

Purpose: describe the mismatch without attacking the current accountant.

Copy tags: Header, Body, Pain Bullets.

Likely state: accounts arrive after year-end; bank cash is hard to interpret; dividends and reserves are estimated; questions arise only when money is moving.

4. Amplification and solution: one compact sequence

Purpose: show why delay costs options, then explain the alternative.

Copy tags: Problem, Consequence, Mechanism, Outcome.

Problem, amplification, and solution do not need three long sections. A compact or pinned progression can work if it is fast, accessible, and does not trap scrolling:

1. records arrive after the event;
2. thresholds and transactions become fixed;
3. current numbers plus a planned review create an earlier decision;
4. the owner acts with the consequence understood.

5. Dream state

Purpose: make the result concrete.

Copy tags: Header, Body, Outcome Bullets.

The result is knowing what can be extracted, what must be reserved, what the next decision changes, and where the business is heading.

6. Specific decision doors

Purpose: let high-intent prospects recognise themselves.

Copy tags: Door Header, Situation, Outcome, Link.

Use a small set: Owner Tax and Extraction; UK and International; Exit Readiness; Accounts and Control. Sectors can sit below or on dedicated pages.

7. Who this is for

Purpose: qualify relationship and complexity.

Copy tags: Header, Fit Bullets, CTA.

Describe owners who want decisions early and will maintain current records. Avoid a random occupation list.

8. Diagnostic first step

Purpose: turn curiosity into a bounded conversation.

Copy tags: Header, Body, Curiosity Bullets, CTA.

The first call identifies structure, current service, deadlines, goals, and the next material decision. Do not imply personalised advice is delivered free on discovery.

9. How it works

Purpose: make delivery understandable.

Copy tags: Diagnose, Plan, Maintain.

Include onboarding and switching. "Maintain" should name the agreed review rhythm rather than sound like passive compliance.

10. Services

Purpose: confirm practical completeness.

Copy tags: Service Header, Short Body.

Corporation tax, annual accounts, VAT/CIS, payroll, company secretarial, self assessment/MTD, bookkeeping, owner tax planning, UK international tax, and exit readiness. Keep descriptions outcome-led and link to detailed pages.

11. Testimonials

Purpose: provide social proof before the personal trust section.

Copy tags: Header, Subheader, Quote, Attribution, Result.

Use different business types to prove general-practice relevance. Resolve attribution first.

12. About Simon

Purpose: convert credentials into human trust.

Copy tags: Header, Body, Credentials, CTA.

Explain how Simon works, what remains direct, and why the smaller-practice model benefits the client. Keep the biography tied to the proposition instead of reciting a career chronology.

13. Plain-English advice

Purpose: demonstrate expertise and support search discovery.

Copy tags: Section Header, Article Title, Summary, Date, Author.

Testimonials should appear above this section, as requested. Articles support the decision but should not interrupt the conversion path.

14. Final CTA

Purpose: close with a clear value trade.

Copy tags: Header, Body, Form Fields, Privacy Note, Button.

Ask only what is needed to qualify and prepare: name, email, business, current situation, and decision or deadline. State what happens after submission.

Homepage restraint

The homepage does not teach the tax system. It identifies the under-advised owner, establishes authority, explains the mechanism, provides proof, and makes switching and the first step feel controlled. Detailed education belongs on decision pages and articles.

Chapter 17 - Copy directions and claims discipline

Strong territories

Before the money moves Most filings describe a decision after it happened. SRJ creates a review point before extraction, relocation, investment, or sale.

Know what is actually yours The bank balance includes money committed to VAT, payroll, suppliers, and tax. Better records and reserves turn apparent cash into an informed decision.

The year-end meeting is too late Use carefully. Annual accounts remain necessary; some planning options expire before they are prepared.

One view of company and owner Useful for extraction and international cases because the tax problem crosses their legal boundary.

International without the fantasy The credible question is what remains taxable or reportable, not how to make UK obligations disappear.

The exit starts in the books Clean financials, defensible adjustments, tax housekeeping, and less buyer uncertainty.

Weak or overused language

- bespoke solutions;
- trusted partner;
- comprehensive services;
- stress-free accounting;
- maximise your wealth;
- tax made simple;
- we care about your business;
- proactive advice, without a cadence;
- one-stop shop, without explicit boundaries.

Claims that need evidence

- exact tax savings;
- client number or years;
- response times;
- specialist status in a technical area;
- PwC role and dates;
- review ratings;
- ICAEW/CIOT membership and logo usage;
- exit or UK/UAE experience;
- direct Simon access at every service level.

Avoid guaranteed savings, relief, or residence results. Use "model," "assess," "identify," "plan," and "coordinate" where outcomes depend on facts.

Chapter 18 - What Simon must decide before final copy

Market and economics

1. Minimum annual fee and target recurring fee.
2. Preferred turnover, profit, employee, and complexity range.
3. Whether low-complexity sole traders and landlords are desirable.
4. Geographic limits and meeting model.
5. Record-quality and software requirements.
6. Sectors or activities SRJ will not serve.

Service model

1. What the recurring foundation includes.
2. Which services include Simon directly and for what work.
3. Review cadence and content.
4. Response expectations and communication routes.
5. Onboarding, clearance, software transfer, and catch-up fees.
6. Which advice is project-priced.

Technical spikes

1. Exact UK/UAE and wider international experience.
2. Foreign adviser relationships and referral process.
3. Written-advice and insurance boundaries for residence and restructuring.
4. Exit experience and corporate-finance/legal partners.
5. Whether Exit Readiness and Owner Tax Reviews can be productised.

Proof and conversion

1. Correct CTA, ACA, and PwC wording with directory links.
2. Correct testimonial attribution and permission.
3. Client outcomes available as short cases.
4. Existing review profiles and review-request process.
5. Discovery call length and qualification standard.
6. What the prospect receives after the call.
7. Whether the first paid step is onboarding, diagnostic, or project advice.
8. Which enquiries should be redirected.

Until these are answered, the structure can be final but the strongest claims cannot be.

Chapter 19 - Research limits and next evidence

This primer can direct the homepage. It does not settle SRJ's commercial market.

Known limits

- Government population figures describe a broad economy, not SRJ's buyers.
- Reddit shows vivid language and failure modes, not frequency or market share.
- Competitor pricing can exclude setup, bookkeeping, or complexity and can change.
- Search Console evidence covers a short period with low query volume.
- Sitemaps show content scale, not revenue, lead quality, or technical accuracy.
- Simon's client profitability, sales objections, delivery capacity, and retention data were not available.

Best next research

1. Interview five strong clients about why they hired, what they feared, and what changed.
2. Review the last 20 qualified enquiries by trigger, service, fee, objection, and outcome.
3. Calculate contribution margin by service and client complexity.
4. Review three competitor enquiry journeys without misrepresentation.
5. Test the homepage with owner-manager, international, and exit-led landing pages.
6. Revisit Search Console after 90 days and separate impressions from qualified enquiries.

The primer should change when real sales evidence contradicts it. Copy is a commercial hypothesis, not a monument.

Chapter 20 - Final position

The agency positioning was not wrong; it was too exclusive for the evidence and practice Simon appears to be building. It should survive as a sector page with agency-specific language, proof, and content.

The general homepage should not retreat to "accountants for all businesses." It should make one market distinction:

| The forms record what happened. The adviser helps decide what happens next.

SRJ's strongest route is a general owner-managed-business practice with specific spikes in owner tax, international complexity, exit readiness, and financial control. Credentials open the door. Service cadence, direct access, proof, and scope clarity justify the relationship.

The useful promise is not that Simon makes tax simple or makes it disappear. It is that material decisions are examined while the owner still has a choice.

That is what "tax planned before the money moves" should mean.

Appendix A - Sources

Official market and profession sources

- ¹ UK Department for Business and Trade, [Business population estimates for the UK and regions 2025](#).
- ² HMRC, [Tax by different customer groups 2025 to 2026](#).
- ³ Administrative Burdens Advisory Board, [2025 annual report](#).
- ⁴ ICAEW, [The advice that businesses want most from their accountants](#), April 2026.
- ⁵ ICAEW, [The 99.9%: Small and medium-sized businesses](#), 2014; dated structural context only.
- ⁶ ICAEW, [Evolution of mid-tier firms](#) and [Consolidation activity](#).
- ⁷ HMRC, [How to choose a tax agent](#).
- ⁸ ICAEW, [What is a chartered accountant?](#).
- ⁹ CIOT, [CTA: the international standard](#) and [Professional Conduct in Relation to Taxation](#).

Official tax and administration sources

- ¹⁰ HMRC, [Corporation Tax rates](#).
- ¹¹ HMRC, [VAT thresholds](#).
- ¹² HMRC, [Income Tax rates and allowances](#).
- ¹³ HMRC, [Employer rates and thresholds 2026 to 2027](#).
- ¹⁴ HMRC, [Pension annual allowance](#).
- ¹⁵ HMRC, [Business Asset Disposal Relief](#).
- ¹⁶ HMRC, [Business Relief for Inheritance Tax](#).
- ¹⁷ HMRC, [Making Tax Digital for Income Tax](#).
- ¹⁸ Companies House, [Identity verification rollout](#).
- ¹⁹ HMRC, [Tax on foreign income: residence](#).
- ²⁰ HMRC, [Foreign Income and Gains regime 2026](#).
- ²¹ HMRC, [Tax if you return to the UK](#).
- ²² HMRC, [Temporary non-residence: post-departure profits](#).

Competitor sources

- ²³ Crunch, [Accounting for limited companies](#), accessed August 2026.
- ²⁴ Alto, [Agency accountant](#) and [homepage](#), accessed August 2026.
- ²⁵ Sidekick Accounting, [homepage](#), accessed August 2026.
- ²⁶ The Wow Company, [homepage](#), accessed August 2026.
- ²⁷ Protax, [homepage](#), accessed August 2026.

Internal SRJ sources

- ²⁸ SRJ, [general-practice-repositioning-2026-08.md](#), including the short Search Console sample and content inventory.

²⁹ SRJ, [seo-plan-2026-08.md](#). Also reviewed: [competitor-keyword-gap-2026-08.md](#), [keyword-demand-discovery-2026-08.md](#), current homepage source, service data, and testimonial source notes.

Reddit field sources

Reddit links are embedded in Section 10. They are qualitative field evidence. Visible votes and comments are mutable; usernames were omitted because identity is not relevant.